Pssst! It's Me. . . The Bogeyman

By Barbara Park

INTRODUCTION

*So, I've asked **a lot** of people – people my age, adults, little kids; and I've come to realize one thing. I am not alone. Almost everyone, at one time or another, has had an overwhelming fear of 1) the dark or 2) even worse: things **IN** the dark. Yes, I'm talking about **monsters**.*

*It's bedtime. You go into your room, look around. No monsters in sight. You flip off the light switch, make a mad dash for your bed, pull the covers over your head as quickly as you can, and (big breath in) hold your breath. . . listening intently for **any** sound. Because you realize there are a few places you may have forgotten to check. The closet??? Under your bed ???*

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BOGEYMAN: Psssssst! Yo! Down here . . . under the bed. It's me, the Bogeyman. Yeah, you hear me, Sparkie. It's the genuine, creepy-crawly, blood-chilling, spine-tingling, can't-avoid-the-urge-to-grab-your-ankle-when-you're-climbing-into-the-sack, Bogeyguy. And the news doesn't get any better,

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Bud, 'cause I'm stew-spewin', gravel chewin' mad.

Oh, quit your shivering, Skeezicks. It isn't you who's got me fuming. Here! Just take a look at this morning's headline!

THE NATIONAL SQUEALER: EVIL BOGEYMAN BELLOWS BOO – BOY SCOUTS GO BERSERK -- THE BOGEYMAN WILL GET YA IF YA DON'T WATCH OUT!

It's a lie, I tell you! That lummox isn't me! I don't go clomping after campers like some bumbling, stumbling Frankenstein. And even if I ***did***, I'd never stop and pose for pictures. I'd lose my job, Jake.

Check it out . . . It's all right here on page three of my Official Bogeyman Contract.

OFFICIAL BOGEYMAN CONTRACT

- The bogeyman's identity must be protected at all costs.
- No one must ever gaze upon your face, or (heaven forbid!) take your picture and then

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(perish the thought!) print it in the tabloids.

- If any of these calamities should occur, we, the management, regret to inform you that your services as the Bogeyman will no longer be required.

There, see? You've gotta help me clear my name! The photo's a fake. A fib, a fraud!

And here's another news flash, Filbert: The Bogeyman doesn't say BOO. Boo's a baby word, Bubbie. It rhymes with toodle-loo. And Winnie the Pooh. And it comes after peek-a-. And right before hoo. And okay, maybe if you scream it really loud at a football game, it might mean the ref made a bad call. But no matter how you shout it, ***boo*** just ain't scary, Skippy.

Want to know a ***scary*** word? I'll give you five of 'em: Go . . . get . . . read . . . for . . . bed. Yeah, you know what I'm talking about. Especially if it's a dark and stormy night, and your pj's are in your closet, all the way in . . . the . . . back. And oh, dearie me, your

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lightbulb burned out last night. But you fight your fear and head upstairs.

Then you stop at the top and peer into the pitch-black darkness of your room. You'd have to be insane to go in there. Am I right, Dwight? But suddenly, your dim-witted feet rush you right across your rug, and deposit you slap dab in front of your closet door which swings open all by itself. *(sound effect)* (Hmmm. That's odd.)

Still, you gather your courage and reach for the hook. And silly-willy me, I been waitin' for you, Jack. And I tenderly tickle your arm with my finest fingernail. *(scream)* And you yell so loud and run so fast, you never even hear me collapse on the closet floor and bust a gut full of giggles. *(insane giggles)*

News flash number three: I don't bellow. Why, I rarely even raise my voice. I'm a professional, Peppie. I whisssssper and I murrrmurrr. And I whoooosh and swoooosh and saaail. And, weather permitting, I even wafffffft on warm summer winds. Which is why, my little whippersnapper, on that

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dark, moonless night last August, when dear old Dad left you all alone in your big backyard, looking for the Little Dipper, you heard just the faintest of sounds as I sneaked up behind you on marshmallow feet and fluttered my eyelashes close to your ear.

Th-then th-th-that's when you s-s-sensed that you *(gulp)* w-w-weren't alone, and the hairs on your neck tried to stand up and run as your knockin', rockin' legs turned to jiggle-jam-jelly. And seriously, Seymour, don't you just ***hate*** it when that happens?

News Flash number four: The Bogeyman does not "Get ya." What does that even mean, get ya? If I ***got*** ya, what would I ***do*** with ya? Where would I ***put*** ya? And what would I ***feed*** ya? My job is to ***scare*** ya. I don't want to ***raise*** ya. So enough already with the get ya garbage.

I'm not "EVIL," Alvin. In fact, I'm not that different from you. I gobble up chicken fingers and I gulp down Gummi Bears. And after eating, I almost always floss my tooth before slipping under someone's bed to catch a few zzzzzz's. Which is

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exactly what I'm about to do now. All this belly-achin' has got me beat. Besides, I'm off-duty, and my cloak is at the clearners. So, start spreadin' the word that this headline *(shakes newspaper)* is hogwash.

Oh, yeah, and kindly keep your smelly sweatsocks off the floor. I'm allergic, okay? Just one wiff of those things and I'm outa here, Dude. I start gaspin' and wheezin' and chokin' and sneezin'. Plus I break out in itchy, splotchy blue blotchies. So, like I said, just keep them – Whoa, Whoa, WHOA!

Hold on a second, Sherlock. You're not takin off those socks now, are you? **You are?** But . . . but I thought we were pals. Hey! *(gasp)* Stop waving them around! *(wheeze)* What's gotten into you anyway? *(sneeze)* Wait! Knock it off! *(itching, scratching, sneezing)* Not all those!! Ugh! Bluck!!! Ick! AAAUUUUUGGGGHHH! I'm gone! *(He flees in a panic to a bedroom down the hall)*

(Still coughing) Pssssssst! Yo! Down here . . . under the bed. It's me, the Bogeyman.

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